Coercive Subtyping for Implicit Functorial Programming

Programming with typeclass-defined combinators like fmap allows programs a great deal of generality and concision, but programmers have to explicitly invoke combinators in the right places in order to get their programs to type check. In this paper, we propose inferring these operations using a coercive subtyping discipline and study the metatheory of the resulting algebra of coercions. For functors, we promote the fmap combinator $\mathtt{fmap} : (A \to B) \to \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$ to a coercion $\mathtt{fmap} : A \to B \leq \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$. We incorporate it into a monomorphic system of coercions for base types, arrow types, and functor types. We prove that the resulting system of coercions is coherent, meaning that all possible choices of coercions from A to B end up equivalent. The proof of the theorem is based on coherence by evaluation, an approach to coherence proofs based on the well-known technique of normalization by evaluation. All definitions and theorems in the paper are checked in Agda, which played a valuable role in the design of the system.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: subtyping, functors, normalization by evaluation

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1 Introduction

Typeclass abstractions like Functor, Applicative, and Monad are essential to modern functional programming. The liberal application of type class combinators allows concise generic programming even in the presence of complex effects and data structures. For example, consider writing a Haskell program that increments integers wrapped in a `Maybe` type.

```
incrMaybe :: Maybe Int -> Maybe Int
incrMaybe (Just x) = Just (succ x)
incrMaybe Nothing  = Nothing
```

This naive definition of `incrMaybe` has to unwrap its argument with a pattern match and then wrap its output back up. A more idiomatic definition uses `<$>`, the fmap combinator, which handles the unwrapping and wrapping. This has the added benefit of being polymorphic, as it will work for any other instance of the Functor typeclass.

```
incrMaybe :: Maybe Int -> Maybe Int
incrMaybe x = succ <$> x
```

In the presence of sufficient type information, we are interested in further reducing the boilerplate involved by making fmap completely implicit. This would permit implementing `incrMaybe` just as one would want to write it, with no use of fmap at all.

```
incrMaybe :: Maybe Int -> Maybe Int
incrMaybe x = succ x
```

Given the declared type, there is really only one way to make this program make sense. It does not typecheck otherwise, so what would be the harm in inserting an fmap? Automatically lifting functions to operate on arrays and other data structures is already prevalent both in programming languages and informal mathematical notation. By the same token, programming with more specific abstractions like applicative functors [5] and monads could also be made simpler by rendering combinators like `bind` and `seq` implicit.

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However, adding new implicit behavior to programming languages may make their semantics unstable and confusing. The semantics of these hidden combinators must be made clear and predictable if they are to become an acceptable part of functional programming practice. In other words, we need to do some metatheory.

First, we point out that these missing combinators ought to be viewed as implicit coercions between types. Implicit coercions are special functions that are inserted during an elaboration phase in order to make a program type check. They are usually drawn from a restricted grammar. Traditionally, coercions are used to permit programs to gloss over details like numerical conversions, which are both tedious and predictable. Our systems of typeclass combinators are more abstract, but (provided they are drawn from lawful Functor instances) they ought to be predictable enough to be baked in to the type checking process. Besides standard lemmas about type inference such as completeness and principal typing, the chief metatheoretic property of interest for coercive subtyping is *elaboration coherence*: for a given input program, all possible results of elaboration are equivalent. Proofs of elaboration coherence rely on *coercion coherence*: for any types A and B, all coercions from A to B are equivalent.

In this paper, we address the problem of inserting implicit typeclass operations for the Functor typeclass by defining a system of coercions and establishing coercion coherence. If integrated into an algorithmic type inference and elaboration phase, it will allow applying pure functions to values of functor type without having to insert calls to fmap. We describe a combined coercion and subtyping judgment

$$c : A \leq B$$

where the coercion c is drawn from a simple combinator calculus. The coercions elaborate into terms in a functional programming language, but come from a much simpler combinator calculus. We add a special coercion

$$\mathsf{fmap} : A \to B \leq \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$$

which lifts its argument into the functor. The other coercions are standard and include, for instance, the mixed-variance coercion $\mathrm{arr}\ c_1\ c_2 : A \to B \leq U \to V$ that turns two coercions $c_1 : U \leq A$ and $c_2 : B \leq V$ into a coercion between the appropriate arrow types.

The system of coercions is declarative, in the sense that it is a good specification of what coercions ought to be available in the system, but it admits possibly many coercions between fixed types A and B. This presents two problems: the rules do not define a deterministic algorithm that derives a coercion given A and B, and two such algorithms may produce inequivalent coercions even though they comply with the declarative system.

We solve both problems. First, we define an algorithmic subtyping system with unique derivations. It is proved sound and complete with respect to the declarative subtyping system and has unique derivations for any given pair of types A and B. Second, in order to get some assurance that this system of coercions is safe, we give a proof of its coherence. Coherence, in this context, says that any two coercions $c_1, c_2 : A \leq B$ are semantically equivalent, in a sense to be made precise later.

Our proof uses what we term *coherence by evaluation*, which is a simple variant of the well-known method of normalization by evaluation. The method uses an isomorphism between declarative and algorithmic translations to reduce the problem of coherence for declarative coercions to the much simpler problem of uniqueness for algorithmic coercions. We begin with declarative coercions $c : A \leq B$ equipped with an equivalence relation $c_1 \simeq c_2$ and algorithmic coercions $n : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$ with unique derivations, i.e., $n_1 = n_2$ for all $n_1, n_2 : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$. We define an evaluation function $\mathrm{eval}\ c$ that sends declarative coercions $c : A \leq B$ to a new datatype of algorithmic coercions $n : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$. Next we define reify, which translates algorithmic coercions back to declarative ones, and prove that

$$A \quad ::= \quad \mathbb{B} \mid A \to A \mid \mathsf{F}\,A$$

$$\boxed{A \le B}$$

$$\textsc{Refl}\ \frac{}{A \le A} \qquad \textsc{Trans}\ \frac{A \le B \qquad B \le C}{A \le C} \qquad \textsc{Arr}\ \frac{U \le A \qquad B \le V}{A \to B \le U \to V}$$

$$\textsc{Mono}\ \frac{A \le B}{\mathsf{F}\,A \le \mathsf{F}\,B} \qquad \textsc{Fmap}\ \frac{}{A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B}$$

Fig. 1. Types and subtype relationships for a calculus with implicit fmap.

reify(eval c) $\simeq c$. Together with the uniqueness of algorithmic coercions, this property implies coercion coherence.

To summarize, our paper makes the following contributions.

- Declarative and algorithmic coercive subtyping judgments for inferring missing uses of fmap in functional programs.
- An equivalence-preserving translation of coercion combinators into lambda calculus.
- A proof of soundness, completeness, and uniqueness for algorithmic coercions.
- A proof of coercion coherence for declarative subtyping based on normalization by evaluation.
- A mechanization of all of the above in Agda.[1]

2 Overview

The types and subtyping rules at issue are shown in Figure 1, which shows a base type, arrow types, and functor types, along with the usual subtyping rules for all of these and the new Fmap rule. This is the declarative system. Everything is standard except Fmap, which permits using functions $A \to B$ at the lifted type $\mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$. This rule may be iterated, permitting the use of a function at $\mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$, $\mathsf{F}\,\mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,\mathsf{F}\,B$, and so on. These rules serve as a good specification of the system, but they have practical and theoretical limitations.

The declarative rules are not suitable for an implementation because they are not deterministic: too many rules apply to possible subtyping queries. Besides the fact that it is always possible to appeal to the Trans rule, queries of the form $A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,U \to \mathsf{F}\,V$ must choose between applying Arr and Fmap. The way the Fmap rule overlaps with the arrow rule is the chief source of technical complications in the sequel.

Declarative coercions (Fig. 2) are nothing more than proof terms for the declarative subtyping judgment. Playing fast and loose with Curry-Howard, we will often refer to the "type" of a coercion: this refers to the subtyping judgment $A \le B$, which is not a type in the object language. However, we do provide a translation of coercions into the object language, and under this translation $A \le B$ does become a type of functions from A to B.

The ambiguity in subtyping derivations discussed above means that for a fixed judgment $A \le B$ there may be many possible coercions c_1, c_2, and so on. In the case of transitivity, the following pair of derivations raises the question of associativity of composition.

$$\frac{\dfrac{c_1 : A \le B \qquad c_2 : B \le C}{c_1 \cdot c_2 : A \le C} \qquad c_3 : C \le D}{(c_1 \cdot c_2) \cdot c_3 : A \le D} \qquad \frac{c_1 : A \le B \qquad \dfrac{c_2 : B \le C \qquad c_3 : C \le D}{c_2 \cdot c_3 : B \le D}}{c_1 \cdot (c_2 \cdot c_3) : A \le D}$$

[1]References to Agda definitions are rendered in `teal`. The file is available in the supplementary material.

$\boxed{c : A \le B}$

$$\textsc{CId}\ \frac{}{\mathsf{id}_A : A \le_{\mathsf{n}} A} \qquad \textsc{CComp}\ \frac{c_1 : A \le B \qquad c_2 : B \le C}{c_1 \cdot c_2 : A \le C}$$

$$\textsc{CArr}\ \frac{c_1 : U \le A \qquad c_2 : B \le V}{\mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2 : A \to B \le U \to V}$$

$$\textsc{CMono}\ \frac{c : A \le B}{\mathsf{mono}\ c : \mathsf{F}\,A \le \mathsf{F}\,B} \qquad \textsc{CFmap}\ \frac{}{\mathsf{fmap} : A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B}$$

Fig. 2. Declarative coercions.

$\boxed{n : A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B}$ $\boxed{na : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V}$

$$\textsc{NId}\ \frac{}{\mathsf{nid} : \mathbb{B} \le_{\mathsf{n}} \mathbb{B}} \qquad \textsc{NMono}\ \frac{n : A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B}{\mathsf{nmono}\ n : \mathsf{F}\,A \le_{\mathsf{n}} \mathsf{F}\,B}$$

$$\textsc{NArr}\ \frac{na : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V}{\mathsf{narr}\ na : A \to B \le_{\mathsf{n}} U \to V} \qquad \textsc{NAFmap}\ \frac{na : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V}{\mathsf{nfmap}\ na : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} \mathsf{F}\,U, \mathsf{F}\,V}$$

$$\textsc{NAArr}\ \frac{n_1 : U \le_{\mathsf{n}} A \qquad n_2 : B \le_{\mathsf{n}} V}{\mathsf{naarr}\ n_1\ n_2 : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V}$$

Fig. 3. Normalized coercions.

The ambiguity of the arrow rules leads to confusion between fmap and arr. Together with composition, this produces another pair of possibly inequivalent derivations. The first uses fmap after arr:

$$\frac{\dfrac{c_1 : U \le A \qquad c_2 : B \le V}{\mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2 : A \to B \le U \to V} \qquad \dfrac{}{\mathsf{fmap} : U \to V \le \mathsf{F}\,U \to \mathsf{F}\,V}}{\mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2 \cdot \mathsf{fmap} : A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,U \to \mathsf{F}\,V}$$

The second uses fmap before arr:

$$\frac{\dfrac{}{\mathsf{fmap} : A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B} \qquad \dfrac{\dfrac{c_1 : U \le A}{\mathsf{mono}\ c_1 : \mathsf{F}\,U \le \mathsf{F}\,A} \qquad \dfrac{c_2 : B \le V}{\mathsf{mono}\ c_2 : \mathsf{F}\,B \le \mathsf{F}\,V}}{\mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_1)\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_2) : \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B \le \mathsf{F}\,U \to \mathsf{F}\,V}}{\mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_1)\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_2) : A \to B \le \mathsf{F}\,U \to \mathsf{F}\,V}$$

Keeping these examples in mind, we now discuss the implications of ambiguity in subtyping derivations. Under a coercive subtyping discipline, type inference becomes an elaboration pass that walks an untyped term e, inserting coercions as it goes, to construct a typed term e'. In theoretical terms, the type system has a judgment shaped like $\Gamma \vdash e \rightsquigarrow e' : A$ where e is an input and e' is an output. It appeals to a subtyping judgment $c : A \le B$ that emits a coercion c, which is brought

back into the grammar of terms by a translation $\mathsf{C}(c) : A \longrightarrow B$. This is all tied together in the subsumption rule:

$$\textsc{Sub}\ \frac{\Gamma \vdash e : A \qquad c : A \leq B}{\Gamma \vdash e \rightsquigarrow \mathsf{C}(c)\ e : B}$$

This process may alter the semantics of e, if they are even defined at all. But there is another problem. In a declarative type system there are, in general, many derivations of the same typing judgment. When dealing with coercive subtyping, this means that while there is generally a unique derivation for a fixed pair of e and e', there may be many possible choices of e' from the same initial e. This means that different implementations of the same type system could give different semantics to the same program.

Coherence for subtyping and elaboration. To ensure the meaning of a program is stable across all possible typing derivations, language designers prove *coherence*. A subtyping judgment is coherent when all coercions $c : A \leq B$ between the same types are semantically equivalent. This means that every path in the "coercion graph" is equivalent or, to borrow a category-theoretic slogan, "all diagrams commute." The elaboration judgment is coherent when all e' with $\Gamma \vdash e \rightsquigarrow e' : B$ are semantically equivalent. Of course, nobody ever runs code that was elaborated by a declarative type system. Instead, implementations of type inference will hew closely to an algorithmic type system including a system of coercions $c_a : A \leq_{\mathsf{a}} B$. By virtue of being algorithmic, this system will have unique coercions and emit unique elaborated terms. It enjoys coercion coherence automatically because its coercions and elaborated terms are not merely equivalent, but equal.

Of course, one could always take the algorithmic judgment as the definition, making coercion coherence true by fiat. This would create other problems. It is easy enough for an algorithmic judgment that has not been properly related to a corresponding declarative system to exhibit incompleteness or unsoundness. These defects would force the careful programmer to study the particular algorithmic system in use, rather than thinking in terms of the conceptually simpler interface provided by the declarative system.

Coherence by evaluation: a recipe. We propose coherence by evaluation, a proof technique for coercion coherence that can exploit the benefits of choosing a distinguished algorithmic system without requiring future algorithmic systems to be related directly to it. Rather than defining coercions only for a deterministic judgment, we begin from a grammar of coercions $c : A \leq B$ for the declarative system. These combinators are equipped with an axiomatized equivalence relation $c_1 \simeq c_2$. The grammar will supply proof terms for the judgment $A \leq B$ without appealing to the grammar of the programming language. The equivalence relation will be finitely axiomatized, in the style of abstract algebra, and will not appeal to the translation C of coercions into expressions. In order to justify the equivalence relation, we check that the translation C is sound:

$$c_1 \simeq c_2 \Longrightarrow \mathsf{C}(c_1) \approx \mathsf{C}(c_2)$$

We then define an algorithmic system $n : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$ of *normal coercions*, so named because they will be used to put (declarative) coercions into normal form. These will enjoy unique derivations. In order to prove coherence, we begin by saying how to translate coercions into normal form and back:

$$\mathsf{eval} : A \leq B \longrightarrow A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$$
$$\mathsf{reify} : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B \longrightarrow A \leq B$$

That eval and reify can be defined at all constitutes proof that the normal system is sound and complete with respect to the declarative system. The next step in normalization by evaluation is

to prove that reify(eval c) $\simeq c$. By exhibiting a left inverse, we show that eval is injective up to equivalence. This implies coherence, since we know eval $c_1 =$ eval c_2 from the uniqueness theorem for normal coercions.

Comparison to Reynolds' method. The coherence problem was studied as early as 1980 by Reynolds [6], who outlined an algebraic approach to coherence of elaboration that complements our own. It was Reynolds who recognized that coercions form a *category*: there are types $A, B, \ldots$ and between any two types there is a set of coercions $\mathsf{Coe}(A, B)$. There should always be identity coercions $\mathsf{id}_A \in \mathsf{Coe}(A, A)$, which do nothing, and an associative and unital composition operation $\circ : \mathsf{Coe}(B, C) \times \mathsf{Coe}(A, B) \to \mathsf{Coe}(A, C)$. Reynolds assumed that coercions form a preorder, that is, for every pair of arrows $c_1, c_2 \in \mathsf{Coe}(A, B)$, $c_1 = c_2$. While this is true (up to equivalence) for any coherent coercive subtyping relation, our approach to coherence is a robust technique for establishing it in the first place. Reynolds goes beyond our results with a proof of full subtyping coherence, although the 1980 paper only treats a first-order language.

3 Defining and justifying the equational theory

The first order of business in establishing coherence is to decide on a reasonable definition of equivalence for coercions. As mentioned above, we take an algebraic approach and define an equivalence using a short list of axioms. It helps that coercion combinators form a category, so most of the axioms are easy to guess. We omit the congruence rules, which say that all the constructors of the coercion grammar respect the equivalence, and the reflexivity, transitivity, and symmetry rules, which make it an equivalence relation.

Definition 1 (Coercion congruence). *The equivalence relation $\simeq$ is the least congruence obeying the following laws, which are implicitly universally quantified.*

$$\mathsf{id} \cdot c \simeq c \qquad\qquad \mathsf{mono}\ (c_1 \cdot c_2) \simeq \mathsf{mono}\ c_1 \cdot \mathsf{mono}\ c_2$$

$$c \cdot \mathsf{id} \simeq c \qquad\qquad \mathsf{arr}\ \mathsf{id}_A\ \mathsf{id}_B \simeq \mathsf{id}_{A \to B}$$

$$c_1 \cdot (c_2 \cdot c_3) \simeq (c_1 \cdot c_2) \cdot c_3 \qquad\qquad \mathsf{arr}\ (c_1 \cdot c_2)\ (c_3 \cdot c_4) \simeq \mathsf{arr}\ c_2\ c_3 \cdot \mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_4$$

$$\mathsf{mono}\ (\mathsf{id}_A) \simeq \mathsf{id}_{\mathsf{F}\,A} \qquad\qquad \mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_1)\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c_2) \simeq \mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2 \cdot \mathsf{fmap}$$

In order, the laws say that coercions form a category, mono is a functor on that category, and arr is a bifunctor on that category. The final law, which we refer to as the *special fmap law*, is unusual because fmap is not a functor on coercions but instead a functor on types. In the equational theory of coercions, all that can be said about fmap is how it interacts with other coercions on arrow types. No rule is needed to describe how it interacts with fmap, since fmap $\cdot$ fmap is, in general, only equal to itself. The special fmap law implies the last pair of ambiguous derivations shown in Section 2 is coherent.

3.1 Compiling coercions correctly

We provide a translation from coercions to simply typed lambda calculus in order to show that our coercions are realizable and their equational theory is accurate. The target lambda calculus includes a type of booleans `bool` and a functor on types `F`. For concreteness, we take the congruence $\approx$ in the target language to be contextual equivalence extended with fmap laws, but it could be any relation that incorporates $\beta\eta$-equivalence, extensionality, and the fmap laws. We then prove that

our coercion translation sends equivalent coercions to congruent typed terms.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{C}(\mathbb{B}) &= \mathtt{bool} \\ \mathsf{C}(A \to B) &= \mathsf{C}(A) \texttt{ -> } \mathsf{C}(B) \\ \mathsf{C}(\mathsf{F}\,A) &= \mathtt{F}\mathsf{C}(A) \end{aligned} \qquad \begin{aligned} \mathsf{C}(\mathsf{id}_A) &= \lambda x : \mathsf{C}(A).\, x \\ \mathsf{C}(c_1 \cdot c_2) &= \lambda x.\, \mathsf{C}(c_2)\ (\mathsf{C}(c_1)\ x) \\ \mathsf{C}(\mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2) &= \lambda f\, x.\, \mathsf{C}(c_2)\ (f\ (\mathsf{C}(c_1)\ x)) \\ \mathsf{C}(\mathsf{mono}\ c) &= \mathtt{fmap}\ \mathsf{C}(c) \\ \mathsf{C}(\mathsf{fmap}) &= \mathtt{fmap} \end{aligned}$$

Proposition 2 (interp-sound). *For all* $c_1, c_2 : A \le B$, $c_1 \simeq c_2 \implies \mathsf{C}(c_1) \approx \mathsf{C}(c_2)$.

Proof. By induction on $c_1 \simeq c_2$. Function extensionality appears necessary in the case for the special fmap law due to it relating composite terms of function type. □

4 Algorithmic judgment and normal coercions

Using the equational theory, we now design the algorithmic system. The idea is to remove the Refl and Trans rules and instead devise a system where they are admissible. We also need to address the overlap between the fmap and narr rules. Our solution is shown in Figure 3. We will sometimes elide the proof terms n and na and just refer to the subtyping judgments $A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B$ and $A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$. We separate the system into normal coercions $n : A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B$ and arrow coercions $na : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$. The normal coercions have exactly one rule for each type former. The arrow coercions include naarr, which performs ordinary mixed-variance arrow subtyping by appealing to two normal coercions, and nfmap, which extends an arrow coercion with one use of fmap on the right. Notice that there is only an identity coercion for base types and other identity coercions have to be built up from the other coercion combinators. Like normal forms for the lambda calculus, these normal forms are not necessarily the simplest or most efficient programs for a given task. In a practical implementation, one would probably want to perform an optimization pass after the fact in order to keep coercions as simple as possible, or rely on a different algorithmic system that produces more efficient proof terms.

4.1 Uniqueness of normal coercions

It is not immediately clear that normal coercions have $n_1 = n_2$ for any $n_1, n_2 : A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B$. The proof of this ought to look like an induction on one paired with some inversion lemmas on the other, but there are issues in the arrow cases. For instance, inverting $na_2 : A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} \mathsf{F}\,U, \mathsf{F}\,V$ suggests that na_2 has the form $na_2 = \mathsf{nfmap}\ na'$ or $na_2 = \mathsf{naarr}\ n_1'\ n_2'$, but both options are possible. Fortunately, there are some invariants preserved by subtyping that will allow ruling out the latter possibility.

The subtyping relations $A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B$ and $A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ exhibit a predictable relationship between the number of leading functors in the types on their left and right. To this point, define the *peel number* of a type to be $\mathsf{peel}(\mathsf{F}\,A) = 1 + \mathsf{peel}(A)$ and $\mathsf{peel}(A) = 0$ otherwise. The peel number is preserved by normal subtyping and increased by arrow subtyping.

Proposition 3 (peel-inv). *Let* $A, B, U,$ *and* V *be types.*

(1) *If* $A \le_{\mathsf{n}} B$ *then* $\mathsf{peel}(A) = \mathsf{peel}(B)$.
(2) *If* $A, B \le_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ *then* $\mathsf{peel}(A) + k = \mathsf{peel}(U)$ *and* $\mathsf{peel}(B) + k = \mathsf{peel}(V)$ *for some nonnegative integer* k.

Proof. By mutual induction on $\le_{\mathsf{n}}$ and $\le_{\mathsf{na}}$. □

With this in hand, we can distinguish arrow coercions. In fact, the k that appears in the invariant for arrow subtyping counts the number of nfmap constructors that appear in the underlying arrow coercion na.

Proposition 4 (ncoe-uniq). *Let A, B, U, and V be types.*

- *If $n_1 : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$ and $n_2 : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$ then $n_1 = n_2$.*
- *If $na_1 : A, B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ and $na_2 : A, B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ then $na_1 = na_2$.*

Proof. By mutual induction on n and na. We show a couple of representative cases.

- Case $n_1 = \mathsf{nmono}\ n_1'$: By inversion, $n_2 = \mathsf{nmono}\ n_2'$ and we can apply the IH.
- Case $na_1 = \mathsf{nfmap}\ na_1'$ with $na_1' : A, B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$: By Proposition 3, we have $\mathsf{peel}(A) \leq \mathsf{peel}(U)$. If $na_2 = \mathsf{nfmap}\ na_2'$ then the IH applies. Otherwise, $na_2 = \mathsf{naarr}\ n_1\ n_2$ for some coercions $n_1 : \mathsf{F}\,U \leq_{\mathsf{n}} A$ and $n_2 : B \leq \mathsf{F}\,V$. Applying Proposition 3 again yields $\mathsf{peel}(A) = \mathsf{peel}(U) + 1$, a contradiction. □

5 Coherence

In this section, we prove that all coercions of the same type are equivalent. We establish our result using the methods of normalization by evaluation, which is more commonly used to derive decidable equality for a language by lifting it from a model that is already equipped with an easily decidable equivalence relation, like syntactic equality. In this section we establish coherence for coercions by lifting it from a proof of uniqueness for normal coercions. In a sense we are deriving a decidable equality that happens to always return true. We are also, by virtue of working with a monomorphic combinator calculus, dealing with a simpler system than normalization by evaluation is typically applied to.

5.1 Reification and evaluation

Normal coercions are immediately interpretable as coercions, as exhibited by the following straightforward definition of reify. Note that the reification of nfmap na puts fmap after the reification of na and not before. This is an arbitrary choice, like the choosing between cons lists and snoc lists. Putting fmap at the front would affect the "bias" of subsequent proofs but all the top-level theorems would say the same things.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{reify} &: A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B \to A \leq B \\
\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}} &: A, B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V \to (A \to B) \leq (U \to V) \\
\mathsf{reify}\ \mathsf{nid} &= \mathsf{id}_{\mathbb{B}} \\
\mathsf{reify}\ (\mathsf{nmono}\ n) &= \mathsf{mono}\ (\mathsf{reify}\ n) \\
\mathsf{reify}\ (\mathsf{narr}\ na) &= \mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\, na \\
\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ n_1\ n_2) &= \mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{reify}\ n_1)\ (\mathsf{reify}\ n_2) \\
\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}\ na) &= \mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\, na \cdot \mathsf{fmap}
\end{aligned}$$

Read through Curry-Howard, the type of reify says that the normal subtyping relation is sound with respect to declarative subtyping.

The other direction amounts to a proof of completeness and is more complex. It is accomplished by the evaluation function, which turns a declarative coercion into a normal coercion of the same type. It relies on two definable operators on normal coercions.

$$\mathsf{mkid}_A : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} A \qquad \mathsf{mkcomp} : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B \times B \leq_{\mathsf{n}} C \to A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} C$$

These correspond to standard lemmas in the metatheory of subtyping. The first proves a reflexivity rule is admissible, while the second proves a transitivity rule is admissible. Evaluation uses these to establish the completeness of normal subtyping. Promoting these results from theorems to functions makes them proof-relevant, which will ultimately allow us to show a stronger result: implicit coercions in both theories behave the same.

The identity and composition operators permit a structurally recursive definition of eval, which is otherwise defined in terms of constructors.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{eval}\ \mathsf{id}_A &= \mathsf{mkid}_A \\
\mathsf{eval}\ (c_1 \cdot c_2) &= \mathsf{mkcomp}\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c_1)\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c_2) \\
\mathsf{eval}\ (\mathsf{mono}\ c) &= \mathsf{nmono}\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c) \\
\mathsf{eval}\ (\mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2) &= \mathsf{narr}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c_1)\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c_2)) \\
\mathsf{eval}\ \mathsf{fmap} &= \mathsf{narr}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ \mathsf{mkid}_A\ \mathsf{mkid}_B))
\end{aligned}$$

The identity operator is defined by induction on type. This helps explain why the normal coercions do not have a built-in nid_A operator for any type A, but only include it for base types. Otherwise, at every type A the two distinct proofs nid_A and mkid_A would both prove $A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} A$, which would break uniqueness (Proposition 4).

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{mkid}_{\mathbb{B}} &= \mathsf{nid} \\
\mathsf{mkid}_{A \to B} &= \mathsf{narr}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ (\mathsf{mkid}_A)\ (\mathsf{mkid}_B)) \\
\mathsf{mkid}_{\mathsf{F}\,A} &= \mathsf{nmono}\ (\mathsf{mkid}_A)
\end{aligned}$$

The composition operator is more complex. It deals with the mutually inductive types of normal coercions and arrow coercions. While most clauses in the definition below are straightforward structural recursion, there is a snag in one case, which composes an arrow coercion ending in an fmap with another arrow coercion. The available fmap constructor in the grammar for *na* only puts fmaps on the right, so we need to push the fmap "through" the second argument, all the way to the end, and adjust the coercion to fit.

At a higher level, we are defining an operation that composes an arrow coercion *na* with an fmap on the left. It has the type $\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}} : \mathsf{F}\,A, \mathsf{F}\,B \leq_{\mathsf{n}} U, V \to A, B \leq_{\mathsf{n}} U, V$ and is defined by only two clauses.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}\ na) &= \mathsf{nfmap}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}}\ na) \\
\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ (\mathsf{nmono}\ n_1)\ (\mathsf{nmono}\ n_2)) &= \mathsf{nfmap}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ n_1\ n_2)
\end{aligned}$$

These rules are exhaustive. The trick here is that if *na* is safe to compose with an fmap on the left, it must have F types in its domain(s). If it has the form $\mathsf{naarr}\ n_1'\ n_2'$, the only way the sub-coercions n_1' and n_2' can be well-typed is by beginning with nmono. This procedure, which pushes an fmap through a term by "demoting" nmono coercions, can be justified by the special fmap law.

With that obstacle cleared, we can define composition for normal coercions by a straightforward recursion.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{mkcomp}\ n_1\ \mathsf{nid} &= n_1 \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}\ \mathsf{nid}\ n_2 &= n_2 \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}\ (\mathsf{nmono}\ n_1)\ (\mathsf{nmono}\ n_2) &= \mathsf{nmono}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}\ n_1\ n_2) \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}\ (\mathsf{narr}\ na_1)\ (\mathsf{narr}\ na_2) &= \mathsf{narr}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1\ na_2) \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ n_1\ n_2)\ (\mathsf{naarr}\ n_3\ n_4) &= \mathsf{naarr}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}\ n_3\ n_1)\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}\ n_2\ n_4) \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1\ (\mathsf{nfmap}\ na_2) &= \mathsf{nfmap}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1\ na_2) \\
\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}\ na_1)\ na_2 &= \mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1\ (\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}}\ na_2)
\end{aligned}$$

We have now fully defined the evaluation function eval. We record some immediate observations about its definition. First, it has the type it was claimed to have: it really does send proofs of $A \leq B$

to proofs of $A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$. This makes normal subtyping complete with respect to declarative subtyping. This permits us to conclude evaluation respects equivalence.

Proposition 5 (eval-sound). *For all $c_1, c_2 : A \leq B$, if $c_1 \simeq c_2$ then* $\mathsf{eval}\ c_1 = \mathsf{eval}\ c_2$.

Proof. Since $\mathsf{eval}\ c_1, \mathsf{eval}\ c_2 : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$, this follows from the uniqueness of normal coercions at a given type (Proposition 4). □

5.2 Reification inverts evaluation

Following the path blazed by normalization by evaluation, we will now prove that reify is a left inverse to eval. This makes eval injective up to equivalence and will allow us to lift uniqueness for normal coercions up to a proof of coherence for declarative coercions. The proof of this lemma exercises all the rules of the equivalence relation $\simeq$ on coercions including the special fmap rule.

The first order of business is to establish that reify is a homomorphism. This means checking that each of the operations we defined on normal coercions in the course of defining eval is sent to its counterpart in declarative coercions. These results only hold up to equivalence.

Proposition 6 (reify-mkid). *For all A,* $\mathsf{reify}\ \mathsf{mkid}_A \simeq \mathsf{id}_A$.

Proof. By induction on A using the identity laws for mono and arr. □

Proposition 7 (reify-na-fmap-l). *If $na : \mathsf{F}\,A, \mathsf{F}\,B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ then*

$$\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{nfmap}_{\mathsf{l}}\ na) \simeq \mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na.$$

Proposition 8 (reify-mkcomp). *Let A, B, U, V, X, and Y be types.*

(1) *For all $n_1 : A \leq_{\mathsf{n}} B$ and $n_2 : B \leq_{\mathsf{n}} C$,*

$$\mathsf{reify}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}\ n_1\ n_2) \simeq (\mathsf{reify}\ n_1) \cdot (\mathsf{reify}\ n_2).$$

(2) *For all $na_1 : A, B \leq_{\mathsf{na}} U, V$ and $na_2 : U, V \leq_{\mathsf{na}} X, Y$,*

$$\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ (\mathsf{mkcomp}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1\ na_2) \simeq (\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_1) \cdot (\mathsf{reify}_{\mathsf{na}}\ na_2).$$

Now we can prove that reify inverts evaluation. The interesting case, which shows that fmap is equivalent to the round-trip reify (eval fmap), has to appeal to the special fmap law.

Lemma 9 (reify-eval). *If $c : A \leq B$, then* $\mathsf{reify}\ (\mathsf{eval}\ c) \simeq c$.

Proof. By induction on c.

- Case $c = \mathsf{id}_A$: By Proposition 6.
- Case $c = c_1 \cdot c_2$: By Proposition 8 and the IH.
- Case $c = \mathsf{mono}\ c$: By the IH.
- Case $c = \mathsf{arr}\ c_1\ c_2$: By the IH.
- Case $c = \mathsf{fmap}$: We reason equationally.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathsf{reify}\ (\mathsf{eval}\ \mathsf{fmap}) &= \mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{reify}\ \mathsf{mkid}_A)\ (\mathsf{reify}\ \mathsf{mkid}_B) \cdot \mathsf{fmap} && \text{By definition} \\
&\simeq (\mathsf{arr}\ \mathsf{id}_A\ \mathsf{id}_B) \cdot \mathsf{fmap} && \text{Proposition 6} \\
&\simeq \mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{arr}\ (\mathsf{mono}\ \mathsf{id}_A)\ (\mathsf{mono}\ \mathsf{id}_B) && \text{Special fmap law} \\
&\simeq \mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{arr}\ \mathsf{id}_{\mathsf{F}\,A}\ \mathsf{id}_{\mathsf{F}\,B} && \text{Identity law for mono} \\
&\simeq \mathsf{fmap} \cdot \mathsf{id}_{\mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B} && \text{Identity law for arr} \\
&\simeq \mathsf{fmap} && \text{Right identity law}
\end{aligned}$$

□

Coherence is an immediate consequence of the lemma.

Theorem 10 (coe-coh). *If $c_1, c_2 : A \leq B$ then $c_1 \simeq c_2$.*

Proof. We reason equationally since $\simeq$ is an equivalence relation. The middle step uses equality, which is finer than $\simeq$ and respected by reify.

$$\begin{aligned} c_1 &\simeq \mathsf{reify}(\mathsf{eval}\ c_1) && \text{by symmetry of } \simeq \text{ and normalization (Lemma 9)} \\ &= \mathsf{reify}(\mathsf{eval}\ c_2) && \text{by uniqueness (Proposition 4)} \\ &\simeq c_2 && \text{by normalization (Lemma 9)} \end{aligned}$$ □

6 Implementation in Agda

All of our definitions and theorems were implemented in Agda, where we made heavy use of dependently typed syntax and dependent pattern matching to keep our theorems concise and our proofs simple. The presentation of the system in the paper glosses over details that were checked by Agda, like the well-typedness of the output of the reification and evaluation functions.

We found Agda well suited to the task of mechanizing normalization by evaluation for coercions. All proof assistants are adequate for algebra over a single sort, but in many-sorted and indexed algebras good pattern matching becomes indispensable. Agda's dependent pattern matching allowed us to use an intrinsically typed syntax and write concise proofs. In Agda, many cases in definitions by recursion which we would otherwise have to prove impossible were actually automatically dispatched by the pattern matching coverage algorithm. In inductive proofs, this makes a big difference in the usability of the system and the efficiency of formalizing metatheory.

Rather than compile the coercion calculus to a shallowly embedded syntax of lambda terms, we interpret them directly as Agda types and terms. The interpretation is parameterized by a functor `F : Set → Set` that obeys identity and composition laws. This means that the Agda proof of Proposition 2 is actually carried out in terms of Agda's propositional equality, not some kind of contextual equivalence. As noted in the pen-and-paper proof, it does seem necessary to assume function extensionality in order to prove the special functor law.

While reasoning about coercions, we rely on a user-defined equivalence relation instead of Agda's propositional equality. While Agda has special "rewrite patterns" for rewriting with equations on the left side of a pattern match, we did not find the same level of built-in support for rewriting with custom equivalences. This means that our proofs end up containing big proof terms that are littered with congruence and transitivity rules, like the following clause from the proof of `reify-eval`. What this term really does is a series of rewrites along `c-arr-fmap`, `reify-mkid`, `c-mono-id`, `c-arr-id`, and `c-id-r`, but most of the space is devoted to declaring where inside the coercion those rewrites happen (the `c-cong-*` subterms) and in what order (the `c-trans` subterms).

```
reify-eval (c-fmap {a} {b}) =
   c-trans (c-sym c-arr-fmap)
    (c-trans
      (c-cong-comp
        (c-refl c-fmap)
        (c-trans
          (c-cong-arr (c-trans (c-cong-mono (reify-mkid a)) c-mono-id)
                      (c-trans (c-cong-mono (reify-mkid b)) c-mono-id))
          c-arr-id))
      c-id-r)
```

7 Perspectives and future work

We have shown that coercive subtyping for functors is coherent. In the future, we are hoping to extend these results to simplify programming with richer abstractions, like applicative functors and monads. These would permit more sophisticated applications of the subtyping discipline, like in the following example of an evaluator for a calculator language.

```
data Exp = Const Int | Add Exp Exp | Mul Exp Exp | Div Exp Exp

maybeDiv :: Int -> Int -> Maybe Int
maybeDiv n1  0 = Nothing
maybeDiv n1 n2 = Just (div n1 n2)

eval :: Exp -> Maybe Int
eval   (Const n) = n
eval (Add e1 e2) = (+) <$> eval e1 <*> eval e2
eval (Mul e1 e2) = (*) <$> eval e1 <*> eval e2
eval (Div e1 e2) = do n1 <- eval e1
                      n2 <- eval e2
                      maybeDiv n1 n2
```

This program mixes uses of applicative and monad combinators, with applicatives used for total operators and monads for the partial one. Under a subtyping discipline that silently inserts monad and applicative combinators, it could simply be written like this.

```
eval :: Exp -> Maybe Int
eval (Const n) = n
eval (Add e1 e2) = eval e1 + eval e2
eval (Mul e1 e2) = eval e1 * eval e2
eval (Div e1 e2) = eval e1 `maybeDiv` eval e2
```

This is a much more appealing definition than the previous one, and like our example in the introduction we expect there be essentially one canonical way to make it typecheck.

Unfortunately, there are a few immediate technical obstacles to achieving this level of brevity in realistic programs while maintaining soundness, decidability, and coherence. A subtyping system for an applicative functor F should include the declarative coercions $\mathrm{pure} : A \leq \mathsf{F}\,A$ and $\mathrm{seq} : \mathsf{F}\,(A \to B) \leq \mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B$. Our normal coercions for plain old functors do not immediately generalize to this setting. The peel invariant (Proposition 3) relied on in some proofs no longer holds because both of the new coercions do not preserve number of leading F symbols in types. By entangling the functor and arrow types, these coercions introduce many more pairs of coercions that can be composed, and designing a system of normal coercions that can choose a canonical form for all these compositions will require further research.

Proving elaboration coherence will probably require more sophisticated methods than the ones used in this short paper. The usual approach is to deploy a logical relation in the style of Reynolds [7], whose famous "bracketing theorem" relates an untyped semantics where subtyping is interpreted by inclusion to a typed semantics where subtyping is interpreted by coercion maps. Here there may be a snag. In the case of functor subtyping, the untyped semantics has to interpret types in such a way that fmap becomes an inclusion

$$[\![A \to B]\!] \subseteq [\![\mathsf{F}\,A \to \mathsf{F}\,B]\!]$$

while still providing a sound model of the rest of the type system. This is an unusual requirement, to say the least, and will require further research.

Polymorphism leads to incoherence. We have not defined an algorithmic type inference and elaboration judgment using our system of coercions or proved it coherent. We expect this to be straightforward for a monomorphic calculus with just fmap, but there are difficulties in extending the result to polymorphic types. Consider a program that applies `head : [a] -> a` to a list of lists. It already typechecks. But it is also possible to insert an fmap, which will make it return a list of the head elements of each list. This makes both of the following results plausible outcomes of elaboration.

```
head [[1,2],[3,4]] = [1,2]
head [[1,2],[3,4]] = [1,3]
```

This clearly violates elaboration coherence. The two expressions even have the same type. In some sense the second example ought to be ruled out, since it lifts a function that does not need lifting, but a naive declarative system will always permit it. We are interested in finding restricted forms of elaboration that can be coherent even in the presence of polymorphic functions.

8 Related work

Promoting fmap to a coercion has some similarity with work on effect systems, where programs are permitted to run in an effect bounded below by the effects they actually require. Effect systems may exhibit incoherence if liftings between effects do not commute. This issue has been addressed by Biernacki and Polesiuk [4], who use a step-indexed logical relation atop an operational semantics to establish the equivalence of terms typed under different derivations.

The categorical point of view on implicit coercions appears to have originated with Reynolds [6], but we address an issue left unhandled in that paper. He begins with a system of coercions that has at most one coercion between any two types and proceeds to prove that certain term-level operations defined at each type, like addition, commute with the coercions; this establishes the coherence of terms built from basic operations in the presence of subtyping. Our theorem takes a step back and begins with a possibly incoherent system of declarative coercions. We show our system of normal coercions has at most one coercion between any two types, but we also show that its equational theory matches the equational theory of the original set of coercions. Instead of checking that it commutes with term level operators, we check that it commutes with the operations of the declarative coercion algebra.

Our application of normalization by evaluation to a coherence problem is certainly precedented, although we are unaware of any applications to algorithmic subtyping. We were particularly inspired by the coherence proof for monoidal categories of Beylin and Dyjber [3], which recovers an old result of Mac Lane from a proof of normalization for monoids. In a sense, a monoid is a single-sorted category (or a category is a many-sorted monoid); our normalization of terms involving identities (reflexivity proofs) and compositions (transitivity proofs) bears formal similarities to Beylin and Dyjber's proof.

Allais et al. [1] describe Frex, a suite of tools for working with single-sorted algebraic theories using normalization by evaluation techniques. Our theories of coercions are multi-sorted: there is one sort $A \leq B$ for every pair of types A and B. This makes the machinery of Frex inapplicable. An extension of Frex to multi-sorted algebraic theories, as proposed by Allais and an overlapping set of authors [2], could subsume portions of our Agda development and make it easier to add new coercions and types to the system. Unfortunately the particular choice of algorithmic system is not something that can be automatically derived.

9 Conclusion

We have presented a subtyping judgment for statically inferring silent uses of the fmap combinator in monomorphic functional programs. Our system uses coercive subtyping, which treats fmap as a coercion that may be inserted wherever the types involved make it make sense. To keep program meaning stable in the face of this potentially intrusive and nondeterministic procedure, we proved coherence of subtyping derivations using a new approach we call *coherence by evaluation*. All our definitions and proofs were checked in Agda.

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